

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: High

WHY IT WORKS

People resist change when it feels like loss — reframing what is at stake shifts the mental model from threat to opportunity. The same information received through a different lens triggers different decisions.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not spin — a reframe reveals stakes that are genuinely there; it does not invent flattering ones.
- Not changing the subject — the surface question still gets answered, just inside a truer frame.
- It is naming what the conversation is actually about, and checking that the other person agrees it is.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Conversations with them get unstuck — they name the thing everyone was circling, and suddenly progress is possible.

Principle: People rarely argue about what a conversation is about; they argue inside whatever frame was set first — reset the frame and you reset the argument.

What you gain

- Circular arguments that finally resolve, because the real issue is on the table
- Negotiations that move once the true blocker is named
- A reputation for seeing to the heart of problems
- Less time lost to proxy battles over details
- Relief in the room — naming the real stakes releases the tension of avoiding them

Why most people fail at it

- They reframe to escape a question that deserved a straight answer, and it reads as evasion.
- They announce the 'real issue' as a verdict instead of offering it as a read.
- They reframe so often it becomes a tic and stops shifting anything.
- Their reframe serves their own position a little too neatly, so it lands as manipulation.

CORE FORMULA

Name what the conversation is actually about -> Shift from surface detail to real stakes -> Invite them into the new frame

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When a conversation is stuck on the wrong thing, say: 'I want to step back — the real question here is...' and name it.

BEST FOR

- Negotiations where both sides are arguing past each other
- Conflicts that are stuck on symptoms rather than causes
- Presentations where the audience is focused on the wrong concern
- Situations where the conversation is at risk of missing what actually matters

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Name — Name what it is actually about

Listen for the issue the conversation keeps orbiting without landing on — recurrence is the clue. Say it plainly, as your read rather than as a fact.

Circling: 'OK, so, back to the rota question again...'

Named: 'We have redesigned this rota three times. I think the real issue is that the workload is not sustainable at this headcount.'

2. Shift — Shift from surface to stakes

Connect the detail everyone is gripping to the larger thing it stands for. Keep the surface question alive — you are relocating it, not dismissing it.

Dismissive: 'The rota doesn't matter, forget the rota.'

Shifted: 'The rota matters — and it will keep breaking until we solve the capacity question underneath it.'

3. Invite — Invite them into the frame

Ask whether your read is right, and let them adjust it. The reframe only works once it is jointly held.

Imposed: 'So that's what this is really about. Moving on.'

Invited: 'Does that match how it feels from your side, or have I misread it?'

FIELD TIP

A reframe is an offer, not a ruling.

The powerful move is not declaring what the conversation is really about — it is proposing it and letting them amend it. A confirmed reframe becomes shared ground; an imposed one becomes the next thing you argue about.

Situation: A team has spent twenty minutes relitigating a minor process step.

Don't: 'You're all missing the point. This is obviously about ownership.'

Do: 'Here is my read: this is really about who owns the decision. Am I close, or is it something else?'

PHRASE BANK

Reframe Phrases · Shifting the frame

- "I want to step back for a moment — the real question here is..."
- "I think we may be arguing about the wrong thing."
- "Let me name what I think is actually at stake."
- "If we solve X, we may still have problem Y. The underlying issue is..."
- "We keep coming back to this because the real concern is..."
- "I want to name what I think is actually going on here."
- "The surface question is X — the deeper question is Y."
- "What are we actually trying to solve?"

Invite Into the Frame · Getting them to engage with the reframe

- "Does that land as the real issue for you?"
- "Am I naming the right thing, or is it something else?"
- "I want to make sure I am naming it accurately — what would you add?"
- "Is the real concern X or is it something deeper?"

Reframing Under Fire · Resetting the frame when pressure is high

- "Before we trade another counter-offer — the real negotiation is about risk, not price."
- "We can keep arguing this line item, or we can talk about what is actually blocking the deal."
- "The question this room keeps circling is not the budget. It is whether we still believe in the project."
- "If we get this wrong, the timeline will not be the thing we regret."
- "Let me say what I suspect we are all thinking: this is about trust, not process."

Personal Reframes · Naming what the argument is really about

- "I do not think we are really arguing about the dishes."
- "Can we pause? I think this is about something bigger than tonight."
- "The plans are not the issue, are they? Tell me what is underneath."
- "I keep snapping about small things because there is a big thing I have not said."
- "We are fighting about logistics when I think we are both just scared."
- "Forget the schedule for a second — are we OK?"

Plain Naming · Saying the real stakes without wrapping

- "This is not about the deadline. It is about whether my work is trusted."

- "Let us stop treating this as a process question. It is a people question."
- "The spreadsheet is a proxy — the real disagreement is about strategy."
- "I will say it plainly: what is at stake is the client relationship, not this invoice."
- "We are debating the wording because nobody wants to debate the decision."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Getting deeper and deeper into a detail that does not matter
Better: Can we look at the bigger picture here?
Best: I want to name what I think is actually at stake. Can we check whether we agree on that?
2. Weak: Reframing to avoid a difficult point
Better: I want to make sure we are solving the right problem.
Best: Reframe that points to the actual issue, not away from it.
3. Weak: Presenting a reframe as if it is the only correct view
Better: I think the real issue is...
Best: This is my read of the real issue — does that match yours?

DECISION TREE

If The conversation is stuck on a detail that does not resolve the real issue

Name the real issue. Invite them to confirm whether you have it right.

"I think we keep coming back to this because the real concern is X — is that right?"

If Both sides are entrenched

Name the shared problem before the competing positions.

"I want to step back — what are we both actually trying to achieve here?"

If You reframe and they resist it

Hold the reframe gently rather than forcing it.

"I may have named it wrong — what would you say the real question is?"

If You use reframes to avoid engaging with the actual issue

Do not. This is a misuse. Engage with the issue first.

SCENARIOS

Negotiation stuck on pricing

Name what is really driving the resistance. — "I wonder if the real concern is not the price but the risk. Can we talk about that?"

Team meeting stuck on a procedural debate

Name the outcome everyone wants and redirect. — "We keep coming back to process — the question underneath that is whether we trust each other on this."

Conflict that is circular

Name the pattern itself. — "We keep having this argument, which tells me there is something unresolved underneath it."

Pitch to an audience that is asking the wrong questions

Name what you think their real concern is before answering. — "I think the question behind that question is whether this is worth the risk. Let me address that."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: We need to adopt this new system or we'll fall behind.

Colleague: (resistant) We're managing fine as we are.

With the technique

You: The question isn't whether to change — it's whether we lead the change or react to it. This system lets us lead.

Colleague: That framing changes how I'm seeing it.

COMMON MISTAKES

Reframing to dodge

Sounds like: 'The real question isn't my missed deadline — it's our whole planning culture.'

Better: 'The deadline was missed and that is on me. There is also a deeper issue worth naming.'

The imposed frame

Sounds like: 'Let's be honest, this is really about your ego.'

Better: 'My read is that this is about feeling excluded from the decision. Is that close?'

Reframe as a reflex

Sounds like: 'Can we zoom out?' — for the fourth time this meeting.

Better: Save the reframe for genuinely stuck conversations — scarcity is what gives it force.

The self-serving frame

Sounds like: 'This isn't about my invoice being late — it's about how much value I bring.'

Better: Choose the frame the evidence supports, even when it does not flatter your position.

Reframing too early

Sounds like: 'Before you even finish — I think this is really about something else.'

Better: Let the surface conversation run long enough to prove it is stuck. Then reframe.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- The conversation shifts to a more productive level.
- Both parties seem relieved to be talking about the actual issue.
- Progress is made that was not possible before the reframe.
- The reframe is confirmed as accurate by the other person.

Signs to adjust

- You are using the reframe to avoid the surface question rather than address it.
- The reframe is not confirmed — you are projecting what you think the real issue is.
- The other person experiences it as manipulative.
- You reframe too often so it loses its effect.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the reframe is dishonest and the actual stakes are as difficult as they appear — manipulation erodes long-term trust.
- When the audience has already processed the full picture and reframing feels like spin.
- In situations requiring direct accountability — reframing can deflect necessary ownership.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'That reframe was me dodging your question. Ask it again — I will answer it straight.'

- "That reframe was me dodging your question. Ask it again — I will answer it straight."
- "I declared what this was 'really about' without asking you. What is it about from where you sit?"
- "I reached for the big picture too fast. Let us finish the actual question first."
- "My reframe suited my side a little too well. Tell me the version from yours."
- "I keep zooming out and it is not helping. Back to the specific issue."
- "I named the stakes wrong just then. Help me name them properly."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Stuck negotiation chain

Name the loop -> propose the real stakes -> invite correction -> re-enter the detail inside the new frame

We have exchanged four offers and moved two per cent.

I do not think price is the blocker — I think it is delivery risk.

Is that fair, or am I misreading it?

If it is risk, let us talk guarantees — the price conversation gets easier after that.

Circular conflict chain

Name the pattern -> name the deeper stake -> check the read -> agree what to solve

This is the third time this month we have had this argument.

I do not think it is about the chores — I think it is about feeling taken for granted.

Is that how it feels for you too?

Then that is the thing to work on — the chores will follow.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC026 — Decision Frame

Decision Frame sets the frame before a choice is made; Reframe the Stakes resets it when the conversation has locked onto the wrong one.

TC010 — Curiosity Question

Curiosity Question supplies the checking move — a genuine question is how a proposed reframe becomes a shared one.

TC014 — Validate the Concern

Validate the Concern keeps the surface worry respected while you name the deeper one — without it a reframe feels dismissive.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the misplaced conversation

Notice one conversation today that seems to be stuck on the wrong thing. Do not intervene yet.

Day 2 — Name the real question

In one conversation, name what you think is actually at stake beneath the surface.

Day 3 — Invite confirmation

After reframing, ask if your read is accurate rather than assuming it is.

Day 4 — Check for misuse

Notice any moment when you used a reframe to dodge an uncomfortable question.

Day 5 — Name the pattern

In a circular conversation, name the fact that it is circular and ask what it is really about.

Day 6 — Full reframe in practice

Use the technique in one high-stakes conversation where the surface discussion is not the real one.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did reframes land well? Were any resisted? Did any feel manipulative?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the real stakes accurately — not just redirect the conversation?
- Did I invite the other person to confirm whether my reframe was right?
- Was the reframe genuine — not a tactic to avoid the real issue?
- Did I stay engaged with the surface question even as I named the deeper one?
- Did the conversation shift to a more productive level after the reframe?
- Did I avoid reframing so frequently that it lost meaning?
- Did the other person seem relieved or more engaged after the reframe?